

Social media society

A Vocabulary preview

1 Match the words in bold with the correct definitions.

- | | |
|---------------------------------|---|
| 1 anxious (adj) | a extremely unkind, or causing someone to be unhappy or upset |
| 2 cruel (adj) | b the writing or pictures on a computer screen that you can see at one time, for example as part of a website |
| 3 get attention (phrase) | c to get someone's interest or to make someone notice something |
| 4 hurt (v) | d worried because you think something bad might happen |
| 5 opinion (n) | e a place on the Internet where information is available about a particular subject, organization, etc. |
| 6 page (n) | f to cause someone pain or injury |
| 7 post (v) | g to put writing or images online where other people can see them |
| 8 site (n) | h the attitude that you have towards something, especially your thoughts about how good it is |

2 Choose the correct word to complete the questions.

- Which social media **sites / opinions** are most popular in your country?
- How many times a day do you **get attention / post** something online?
- Do you click on advertising on different web **pages / opinions**?
- Do you worry your comments might **hurt / post** someone's feelings?
- When you put things on social media do you care about other people's **pages / opinions**?
- What do you do when someone writes something negative or **cruel / anxious** about someone you know?
- Do you feel **cruel / anxious** when people do not reply to your messages?
- Do you like it when one of your pictures or videos gets a lot of **attention / anxious** from other people?

3 Discuss the questions from Exercise 2 with a partner.

B Before you read

Read the first sentence of *Social media society*. Work with a partner and predict the topics the text might cover.

Predicting

SOCIAL MEDIA SOCIETY

1 Social media is changing everything

Social media is changing how we communicate, how we do business, and how we live in society. People use it to stay in touch with others, to get people's attention and to check the news. People can connect with celebrities and even communicate with members of the government through their social media profile. When we consider this is only 20 or 30 years after the start of the Web it is not surprising that it is considered one of the biggest ever changes in modern society. So, has social media been a positive or negative development for society?

2 People are less connected

Many people argue that social media makes young people antisocial. In 1998 psychiatrist Tamaki Saito invented the term "hikikomori" which translates into English as avoiding social contact. It describes a growing number of young men who shut themselves away in their bedrooms from society and use technology more and more. Some people think there are between a quarter and one million people like this in Japan. Research around the world suggests this is not only a Japanese problem but one that exists around the world.

3 The only way to socialize

However, other people believe that social media is not more popular because young people are more antisocial. In comparison to the past, many children are not allowed out as much to play. As a result, many use social media to stay in touch with friends because they are not allowed to see them as often. Teenagers want to spend time together and social media is allowing them more contact than they could normally have. It also allows them to feel part of a wider group.

4 Not just for young people

Some think the Internet is just for young people, but this trend is slowly changing. One of the fastest growing groups of social media users is now grandparents who are using it to keep in touch with other people. Since people now move around a lot for work, many grandparents use it to keep in touch with their own children or grandchildren. It also provides the opportunity to socialize when people cannot move around as much as they once did. From reconnecting with old friends to adding new ones, social media has a big positive effect on how we communicate.



2 READING

5 Online profile

Though social media helps us to communicate with other people, it can also change how we see ourselves. Some argue that social media makes us compare ourselves more to other people because we often just post the highlights of our lives. This makes us feel anxious about what other people think of us and can make people depressed. When we see the lives of celebrities and profiles of companies, many people forget that it is carefully created and not real. Both the companies and people use social media to create an image and a version of themselves. Like these people, even most normal people only show the interesting parts of their lives. Selfies are rarely the first photo someone took. People take hundreds until they get the right photo that gets the attention and comments they want.

6 Being popular

Equally, social media is now often considered a popularity contest. From how many people follow us to how many “likes” we get, it can have a big effect on how we feel about ourselves. People often feel anxious about how many “likes” they get on a picture or comment. Many people feel hurt if people don’t like their pictures or posts. People are often so worried about displaying their life in a way that makes them look interesting that they spend less time actually doing healthy activities with other people. This is connected to our human need to feel part of a group. Unfortunately, many connections and friendships online are not real friendships. Of course, many people do have good friends online, but at the same time we can have many false connections just to make ourselves feel more popular.

7 Wanting everything now

Social media also makes us want everything now. The idea of wanting something immediately is connected to another basic human need for food, water, and shelter. However, this need means we now want the latest phone, tablet, or car straight away. Social media increases this feeling. We can upload videos, photos, and updates and get quick feedback from our network. We reply almost immediately to e-mails and posts. There are many instances where certain things in life are better. We no longer have to send letters and wait days or weeks for a reply. Smartphones mean we don’t need to wait for a cab or a table at a restaurant. Movies and TV play immediately. Unfortunately, we are now becoming much worse at waiting for things and social media is in part making this issue worse.

8 Time to stop?

On the one hand, social media makes our world more connected than ever. On the other hand, it also makes many people feel more anxious about their own image, creates false friendship groups, and many people are less patient. People can be so focused on their online lives that they lose time and sleep and ignore the world around them. People who give up social media can feel more connected to their work, their relationships, their family, their friends, and themselves. Perhaps we all need to take a break.

GLOSSARY

popularity contest (n) an attempt to be more popular and liked than other people

C Global reading

- 1 Read *Social media society* quickly and check your predictions.

Arguments can be in the same paragraph, or a positive paragraph can be followed by a negative paragraph. You can identify an argument with key words and phrases such as: *some people believe, many people argue, however.*

- 2 Read the text and highlight the phrases that show that an argument or opinion is being presented.
- 3 Match each argument with a paragraph in the text.
 - A Social media is good for younger and older people. ____
 - B Social media means people spend more time on their own. ____
 - C Social media lets younger people socialize. ____
 - D Social media makes people feel bad when they compare themselves to other people. ____
 - E Social media makes us want everything now. ____
 - F Social media makes us have false friendships. ____

D Close reading

Read the text again. Do these statements agree or disagree with the opinions in the text or is no information given? Write *Y* (Yes), *N* (No), or *NG* (Not Given).

- 1 Social media is one of the main changes in modern society. ____
- 2 Hikikomori is just a Japanese problem. ____
- 3 Teenagers are not addicted to social media. ____
- 4 Celebrity profiles show stars' real lives. ____
- 5 People post photos to get attention. ____
- 6 Social media does not affect other parts of our life. ____
- 7 Social media has caused people to lose their jobs. ____
- 8 Technology has made us less able to wait. ____

E Critical thinking

- 1 Decide if you agree or disagree with each of these statements.
 - 1 Social media makes people feel anxious and depressed.
 - 2 Social media makes people want everything now.
- 2 Compare your opinions in groups and give your reasons.